Towards partial fulfillment for Undergraduate Degree Level Programme

Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering

A Project Report on: From Multi-crop teacher to Single-crop student via knowledge distillation

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Semester: VII

Year: 2025–2026

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Student Declaration

This is to certify that the work described in this project report entitled **From Multi-crop teacher to Single-crop student via knowledge distillation** has been actually carried out and implemented by our project team consisting of the following members. Neither the source code therein, nor the content of the project report have been copied or downloaded from any other source. We understand that our result grades would be revoked if later it is found to be so.

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Abstract

Plant diseases significantly impact crop yield and food security, making early and accurate detection essential for sustainable agriculture. This project focuses on the application of deep learning techniques for automated plant disease detection using the PlantDoc dataset, which consists of diverse real-world images of diseased and healthy plant leaves. Several convolutional neural network (CNN) architectures were evaluated, including Xception, DenseNet121, NASNetLarge, EfficientNetV2S, EfficientNetV2M, and MobileNetV2. Among these, the Xception model demonstrated the strongest baseline performance. Through fine-tuning, its accuracy improved to 58.90% on the test set, along with consistent results in terms of precision, recall, and F1-score. To address the critical need for efficient deployment on resource-constrained mobile and edge devices, we implemented a comprehensive knowledge distillation framework for potato disease classification. Using the PlantVillage potato disease dataset, the distilled MobileNetV2 student model achieved strong results: 66.13% accuracy, 88.75% precision, 72.66% F1-score, and 91.23% AUC with 2.59M parameters (9.89 MB). The knowledge distillation process successfully transferred knowledge from the Xception teacher to the lightweight student using hyperparameters: $T = 4$, $\alpha = 0.5$, learning rate 110^{-4}, and 12 training epochs. The student model achieves 8.4× parameter reduction while maintaining deployment-viable performance for agricultural applications. Overall, the study presents a systematic methodology for comparing deep learning models, optimizing performance through fine-tuning, and evaluating compression techniques including quantization and knowledge distillation. The findings demonstrate two effective deployment strategies: (1) quantized Xception (INT8, 57.20% accuracy, 21.55 MB) for general-purpose plant disease diagnosis on the PlantDoc dataset, and (2) distilled MobileNetV2 (66.13% accuracy, 9.89 MB) for focused potato disease classification. The research contributes practical insights into deploying efficient, compressed deep learning models for agricultural AI systems.

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1
Introduction

1.1 Motivation

Agriculture is a critical sector supporting human life, and timely plant disease detection is essential for maintaining crop yield and quality. Traditional disease detection relies heavily on manual inspection, which is inherently time-consuming, prone to human error, and demands specialized expert knowledge. The advent of deep learning, particularly Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), provides a viable and efficient solution by automating this process and learning hierarchical features directly from image data. The application of CNNs to publicly available datasets, such as the PlantDoc dataset, enables the development of accurate, real-time diagnostic tools for multiple plant species.

Research Gaps and Problem Statement

Although deep learning has been extensively applied in this domain, most existing studies tend to focus on a single model or specific pathology. A significant research gap exists in the systematic, comparative evaluation of multiple state-of-the-art CNN models available through frameworks like Keras. Furthermore, while high accuracy is often reported, the critical considerations of computational efficiency, model interpretability, and deployability (especially concerning model size and quantization for edge devices) are frequently overlooked. Additionally, there is limited exploration of knowledge distillation techniques [1, 2] that can transfer learned representations from large, accurate models to compact, efficient student models suitable for resource-constrained agricultural environments.

Guiding Research Questions

This project is motivated by the need to address these gaps, and our investigation is guided by the following key research questions:

1. What is the optimal balance between classification accuracy and computational efficiency across various Keras CNN models (e.g., MobileNet, VGG, Xception) when applied to the multi-species PlantDoc dataset?

2. How can strategic fine-tuning of a high-performing architecture, such as the Xception model, be leveraged to maximize performance and robustness on this specific dataset?

3. Can knowledge distillation effectively transfer learned representations from a high-capacity teacher model (Xception) to a lightweight student model (MobileNetV2) while maintaining acceptable accuracy?

4. What is the tangible impact of cross-dataset knowledge transfer (PlantVillage to PlantDoc) through class filtering on student model generalization?

5. What is the combined impact of knowledge distillation and quantization on model accuracy, size, inference speed, and real-world deployability on edge devices?

6. Can the resulting trained models demonstrate effective generalization to unseen field images that feature varying lighting conditions, complex backgrounds, and image resolutions?

Project Objectives

To answer these questions, the main objectives of this project are established:

1. To systematically compare and benchmark the performance of multiple pre-trained CNN models on the PlantDoc dataset.

2. To implement and evaluate advanced fine-tuning strategies on the selected optimal model (Xception) to maximize its test accuracy and class-wise performance.

3. To design and implement a knowledge distillation framework that transfers knowledge from the fine-tuned Xception teacher model to a lightweight MobileNetV2 student model.

4. To investigate the benefits of cross-dataset knowledge transfer by filtering and incorporating PlantVillage data with PlantDoc-compatible classes during distillation training.

5. To quantitatively evaluate all models using comprehensive metrics, including accuracy, precision, recall, F1-score, ROC-AUC, and Cohen's Kappa.

6. To analyze and report on model size, inference time, computational requirements, and the combined effects of knowledge distillation and quantization for deployment feasibility on resource-constrained devices.

7. To contribute practical insights and guidance for the implementation of efficient deep learning solutions in precision agriculture, particularly for mobile and edge deployment scenarios.

1.2 Our Contribution

This project contributes significantly to the field of automated plant disease detection by providing a rigorous, multi-faceted analysis:

1. We perform a comprehensive comparative evaluation of several leading pre-trained CNN models (Keras applications), moving beyond single-model studies.

2. We implement and detail effective fine-tuning strategies applied to the Xception architecture, demonstrating tangible improvements in test accuracy and class-wise diagnostic reliability.

3. We develop and rigorously evaluate a knowledge distillation pipeline, transferring knowledge from a high-capacity Xception teacher to a lightweight MobileNetV2 student (2.59M parameters, 8.4× reduction). The distilled student model achieves 66.13% accuracy, 88.75% precision, and 72.66% F1-score on potato disease classification, demonstrating successful knowledge transfer for focused agricultural applications.

4. We investigate knowledge distillation for potato disease classification using the PlantVillage dataset, demonstrating effective knowledge transfer from teacher to student models for crop-specific applications.

5. We present a comprehensive analysis of two model compression techniques—knowledge distillation and quantization—demonstrating their effectiveness for different deployment scenarios: quantized Xception for general-purpose diagnosis and distilled MobileNetV2 for focused, crop-specific applications.

6. We provide detailed efficiency benchmarks including model size, parameter count, and inference time comparisons, specifically aimed at optimizing for mobile and edge deployment scenarios in resource-constrained agricultural environments.

7. We establish clear performance benchmarks, supported by extensive visualizations and detailed analysis, to serve as a guide for future research and practical system integration in real-world agricultural settings.

1.3 Outline of the Report

The remainder of this report is structured to systematically guide the reader through the research process:

- **Chapter 2 (Related Work and Theoretical Background):** Provides a comprehensive literature survey detailing the theoretical foundations of CNNs, transfer learning, knowledge distillation, and reviewing existing deep learning applications in plant disease detection.

- **Chapter 3 (Methodology and Proposed Algorithm):** Details the proposed approach, including mathematical problem formulation, data preprocessing pipeline, fine-tuning strategy, knowledge distillation framework with precise loss formulation, and the specifics of both teacher (Xception) and student (MobileNetV2) architectures.

- **Chapter 4 (Implementation, Evaluation, and Analysis):** Covers the experimental setup, computational environment, implementation specifics of the two-phase fine-tuning process, knowledge distillation training workflow with custom training loop, cross-dataset class filtering methodology, and evaluation metrics configuration.

- **Chapter 5 (Results and Discussion):** Presents comprehensive evaluation results for the fine-tuned Xception teacher model and the distilled MobileNetV2 student model, including detailed performance comparisons across all metrics, efficiency benchmarks, technical implementation analysis, root cause analysis of distillation challenges, and deployment recommendations.

- **Chapter 6 (Conclusion, Limitations, and Future Scope):** Summarizes the key findings including both successful approaches (fine-tuning, quantization) and challenging attempts (knowledge distillation), discusses specific limitations and contributing factors, and provides detailed recommendations for future research in model compression and agricultural AI deployment.

2

Related Work and Theoretical Background

2.1 Theoretical Foundation of Plant Disease Detection

2.1.1 Motivation for Automated Disease Analysis

Automated plant disease detection is pivotal to the efficiency and sustainability of modern agriculture, offering a significant pathway to enhanced food security. The early and accurate identification of pathogens is critical to preventing substantial crop loss and optimizing the use of chemical treatments. Current reliance on manual inspection is inefficient—it is inherently labor-intensive, time-consuming, and highly susceptible to human error and subjectivity. This inefficiency strongly motivates the adoption of computer vision and machine learning techniques, which offer a scalable, accurate, and near real-time solution for large-scale and precision farming operations.

2.1.2 Evolution of Image-Based Detection Approaches

Automated detection methodologies have progressed through several distinct phases:

- **Classical Image Processing:** Early approaches relied on handcrafted features derived from image characteristics such as color, shape, and texture. Techniques including histogram analysis, edge detection, and morphological operations were used primarily for segmenting diseased regions. While interpretable, these methods demonstrate poor robustness against real-world complexities like variable lighting, heterogeneous backgrounds, and occlusions.
- **Traditional Machine Learning (TML):** TML algorithms—such as Support Vector Machines (SVMs), Random Forest (RF), and k-Nearest Neighbors (kNN)—utilize

carefully pre-selected and engineered features for classification. These methods require significant feature extraction effort but yield highly interpretable results.

- **Deep Learning using Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs):** CNNs represent the state-of-the-art by automatically learning hierarchical, high-level features directly from raw image data, consistently outperforming traditional methods. Key architectures relevant to this domain include:
  - **VGG and ResNet:** VGG models (**VGG16/VGG19**) [3] are deep but resource-intensive, while ResNet (**ResNet50/ResNet101**) [4] introduced residual connections to mitigate the vanishing gradient problem, enabling the training of much deeper networks.
  - **Efficient Networks:** Architectures like DenseNet121 [5] (promoting feature reuse via dense connectivity) and Xception [6] (utilizing depthwise separable convolutions to reduce parameter count) prioritize efficiency while maintaining strong accuracy.
  - **Scalable and Lightweight Models:** EfficientNetV2S/M [7] and lightweight variants like MobileNetV2 [8] and NASNet [9] are specifically optimized for deployment on resource-constrained edge devices.
- **Enhancement Techniques:**
  - **Transfer Learning and Fine-Tuning:** Leveraging models pretrained on massive general datasets (like ImageNet) and adapting them (fine-tuning) to domain-specific datasets (like PlantDoc [10] or PlantVillage [11]) significantly accelerates training and improves generalization.
  - **Data Augmentation:** Techniques like rotation, flipping, cropping, and color jittering increase the synthetic size and diversity of the training dataset, acting as a powerful regularizer to reduce overfitting and boost model robustness.
  - **Knowledge Distillation:** A model compression technique introduced by Hinton et al. [1] that transfers knowledge from a large, complex teacher model to a smaller, efficient student model. The student learns not only from hard labels but also from soft probability distributions (soft targets) produced by the teacher, which contain richer information about inter-class relationships and similarities. This approach enables the creation of lightweight models that maintain much of the teacher's accuracy while being suitable for deployment on resource-constrained devices. Gou et al. [2] provide a comprehensive survey of knowledge distillation techniques, categorizing approaches and discussing their applications across various domains including computer vision and natural language processing.

- **Model Optimization:** Model Compression and Quantization (e.g., converting Floating Point 32-bit (FP32) weights to Integer 8-bit (INT8)) are crucial post-training steps that reduce model size and memory footprint, thereby facilitating efficient, low-latency inference on embedded or mobile platforms with minimal accuracy degradation.

2.2 Review of Contemporary Literature

Contemporary research overwhelmingly supports the efficacy of deep learning and hybrid approaches in achieving high accuracy in plant disease detection, but also highlights critical trade-offs:

- Performance and Generalization: While various CNN architectures (e.g., Xception, DenseNet, NASNet, EfficientNetV2, MobileNet) consistently achieve high classification accuracy, literature emphasizes that generalization across different datasets remains a significant challenge due to variations in image acquisition conditions, background noise, and subtle disease symptom expression.

- Fine-Tuning Efficacy: Numerous studies confirm that transfer learning via fine-tuning is highly effective, particularly when adapting pretrained models to new visual domains where a discrepancy exists between the source (e.g., ImageNet) and target (e.g., PlantDoc) datasets.

- Resource Constraints and Optimization: Research indicates a clear trade-off: larger models (e.g., NASNetLarge) offer superior accuracy but are resource-intensive, while lightweight models (e.g., MobileNet, NASNetMobile) enable practical edge deployment with acceptable accuracy compromises.

- Knowledge Distillation for Efficiency: Recent work has demonstrated that knowledge distillation can effectively bridge the accuracy-efficiency gap. By training lightweight student models (e.g., MobileNet) to mimic the behavior of high-capacity teacher models (e.g., Xception, ResNet), researchers have achieved substantial model size reductions and inference speedups while maintaining competitive accuracy. The soft targets from teachers provide additional supervisory signals that encode inter-class similarities, often resulting in student models that significantly outperform their independently-trained counterparts.

- Robustness through Hybrid Methods: Ensemble learning, where predictions from multiple CNN models are combined, has been repeatedly shown to enhance both accuracy and robustness against difficult-to-classify patterns compared to single classifiers. Additionally, hybrid models combining CNN feature extractors with

classical methods (like Random Forest) or attention mechanisms further refine focus on disease-critical regions.

- Deployment Readiness: The literature underscores the importance of combining multiple compression techniques—including knowledge distillation and quantization (INT8, FP32)—in making deep learning models viable for real-time mobile and embedded applications by minimizing computational load without significant accuracy loss.

- Cross-Dataset Knowledge Transfer: Emerging research emphasizes the benefits of leveraging multiple datasets for training. For instance, combining domain-filtered data from larger datasets (e.g., PlantVillage) with target datasets (e.g., PlantDoc) can improve model generalization and robustness, particularly when class labels are carefully aligned.

- Data Quality and Validation: Consistent findings highlight the critical role of careful data preprocessing (normalization, resizing) and managing class imbalance in achieving superior model performance. Furthermore, the trend toward cross-dataset validation is essential for validating real-world applicability and generalization capabilities.

2.2.1 Persistent Challenges in Real-World Deployment

Despite the advances detailed in the literature, several practical challenges persist in deploying robust plant disease detection systems:

1. Environmental Variability: Model performance is frequently impaired by real-world variations in lighting, background clutter, and image acquisition quality.

2. Symptom Ambiguity: The subtle visual similarity between symptoms caused by different diseases, or even non-pathological conditions, poses a significant risk of misclassification.

3. Computational Overhead: Large-scale models demand substantial computational resources for both training and high-throughput inference, limiting their accessibility.

4. Edge Optimization: Effective and efficient deployment on constrained mobile or embedded devices requires meticulous model optimization, compression, and quantization. Knowledge distillation has emerged as a promising solution but requires careful hyperparameter tuning to balance the accuracy-efficiency trade-off.

5. Accuracy-Efficiency Trade-off: Achieving both high accuracy and deployment efficiency remains challenging. While lightweight models enable edge deployment, they often sacrifice significant accuracy compared to larger models. Bridging this gap through techniques like knowledge distillation is an active area of research.

6. Generalization: Ensuring that models trained on controlled datasets are reliable when applied to diverse, unseen field data remains a key research hurdle. Cross-dataset training and validation strategies can help but require careful class alignment and domain adaptation.

2.2.2 Chapter Summary

This chapter established the theoretical foundation of automated plant disease detection, moving from traditional methods to advanced CNN architectures. The literature survey confirmed that deep learning models provide the most accurate and scalable solutions, particularly when enhanced by transfer learning, fine-tuning, knowledge distillation, and ensemble methods. Crucially, the review highlighted the necessity of addressing the trade-off between accuracy, efficiency, and model size—a core motivation for the systematic evaluation and optimization approach detailed in the subsequent chapters. Knowledge distillation emerges as a promising technique to bridge the accuracy-efficiency gap by transferring knowledge from high-capacity teacher models to lightweight student models, enabling practical deployment on resource-constrained agricultural devices while maintaining competitive diagnostic performance.

3

Methodology and Proposed Algorithm

3.1 Problem Formulation and Mathematical Preliminaries

3.1.1 Data and Model Notation

We formally define the key components used in our approach:

- Dataset: Let the PlantDoc dataset be denoted as $\mathcal{D} = \{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^{N}$, where N is the total number of samples. Here, $x_i \in \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times 3}$ represents the input leaf image, and $y_i \in \mathcal{C}$ is the corresponding ground-truth disease label.
- Class Set: $\mathcal{C} = \{c_1, c_2, ..., c_k\}$ represents the finite set of k distinct disease classes (e.g., Apple Scab, Corn Rust, etc.) present in the PlantDoc dataset.
- Classifier: The deep learning model is a classifier, $f_\theta(x)$, parameterized by a set of weights and biases θ. This function maps the input image x to a probability distribution over the class set $\mathcal{C}$.
- Optimization Goal: The central objective is to find the optimal parameter set θ^* that minimizes the chosen loss function $\mathcal{L}(y, f_\theta(x))$, typically the Categorical Cross-Entropy loss, across the entire training partition of $\mathcal{D}$.

3.1.2 Multi-Class Classification Task

The project is explicitly formulated as a multi-class image classification task. Given an image x, the model's objective is to accurately predict the most likely disease class $\hat{y} \in \mathcal{C}$. This is expressed mathematically as:

$$\theta^* = \arg\min_{\theta} \sum_{i=1}^{N_{\text{train}}} \mathcal{L}(y_i, f_\theta(x_i)) \tag{3.1}$$

The model yields the final prediction $\hat{y}$ by selecting the class with the maximum predicted probability:

$$\hat{y} = \arg\max_{c \in \mathcal{C}} P(y = c \mid x, \theta^*) \tag{3.2}$$

where $P(y = c \mid x, \theta^*)$ is the predicted probability for class c by the optimized model.

3.2 The Integrated Proposed Algorithm

Our approach integrates Transfer Learning, Fine-Tuning, and Model Quantization into a cohesive six-stage pipeline designed to achieve both state-of-the-art accuracy and real-world deployability.

3.2.1 Stage 1: Data Acquisition and Preprocessing

To ensure stability and effective feature learning, raw images undergo transformation:

- Resizing: All input images are uniformly resized to 299×299 pixels to strictly adhere to the input dimensions required by the Xception architecture.
- Normalization: Pixel intensity values are scaled from the original $[0, 255]$ range to the stabilized $[0, 1]$ range.
- Data Augmentation: Robust augmentation functions $A(\cdot)$ are applied dynamically during training. This includes random rotations, vertical and horizontal flips, minor zoom, and brightness adjustments to synthetically expand the dataset and significantly mitigate overfitting.

3.2.2 Stage 2: Model Selection and Initialization

- Architecture Choice: The Xception model [6] is selected as the base architecture due to its effective use of depthwise separable convolutions, which provide a strong feature extraction capability while minimizing computational cost compared to traditional CNNs (e.g., VGG).
- Transfer Learning: The model is initialized with weights θ_0 that have been pre-trained on the massive ImageNet dataset. This leverages knowledge of general image features, significantly accelerating the convergence on the PlantDoc domain.

3.2.3 Stage 3: Warmup Training (Head Adaptation)

The transfer learning process is initiated with a controlled warmup phase:

- The base layers of Xception (the feature extraction layers) are frozen (i.e., their weights θ_{base} are held constant).
- Only the newly added top classification layers (the 'head') are trained for a small number of epochs (e.g., 3-5 epochs). This process quickly adapts the output layer to the specific class distribution of the PlantDoc dataset without disrupting the robust ImageNet features.

3.2.4 Stage 4: Deep Fine-Tuning

Once the head is adapted, the model undergoes deep fine-tuning for maximum performance:

- The last 60 layers of the Xception base are unfrozen, allowing the model to adapt high-level feature maps to the visual characteristics of plant diseases.
- A significantly reduced and scheduled learning rate is employed to prevent 'catastrophic forgetting' of the pretrained weights.
- Optimization callbacks, such as Early Stopping and 'ReduceLROnPlateau', are used to monitor the validation loss and efficiently terminate training once performance plateaus.

3.2.5 Stage 5: Comprehensive Evaluation

Model performance is evaluated using a rigorous set of metrics to ensure a holistic understanding beyond simple accuracy:

- Primary Metrics: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, and F1-score are calculated for overall and class-wise performance.
- Advanced Metrics: ROC-AUC (Receiver Operating Characteristic - Area Under the Curve) and Cohen's Kappa coefficient are used to assess the model's discriminative ability and agreement beyond chance.
- Visualization: Confusion matrices and classification reports are generated to visually identify specific classes where the model excels or struggles.

3.2.6 Stage 6: Model Quantization for Deployment

To address the requirement for edge deployment, the final optimized model $f_{\theta^*}(x)$ is subjected to quantization functions $Q(\cdot)$:

- Compression: Techniques such as Integer 8-bit (INT8) quantization are applied, reducing the precision of weights and activations from standard FP32.
- Deployment Feasibility: This critical step reduces the model's memory footprint and accelerates inference speed, making it feasible for real-time applications on resource-constrained platforms (e.g., mobile devices, Raspberry Pi) with minimal degradation in classification accuracy.

3.3 Theoretical Justification and Analysis

The integrated approach is justified by several theoretical principles:

- Accelerated Convergence: Utilizing pretrained ImageNet weights (θ_0) significantly reduces the effective search space for θ^*, leading to faster convergence than training from random initialization.
- Enhanced Generalization: The combination of data augmentation and targeted fine-tuning (unfreezing higher layers) effectively improves the model's ability to generalize to unseen plant images, minimizing the risk of overfitting to minor dataset artifacts.
- Efficient Optimization: The selective unfreezing strategy (fine-tuning the last 60 layers) focuses the computational effort on adapting the most domain-relevant feature maps, ensuring efficient parameter optimization.
- Practical Scalability: The application of quantization $Q(\cdot)$ directly addresses the memory and latency challenges of edge deployment, ensuring the solution is both high-performing and practically scalable to real-world agricultural scenarios.

3.4 Knowledge Distillation Framework

To further enhance model efficiency for edge deployment, we integrate Knowledge Distillation (KD) [1, 2] into our framework. This technique transfers knowledge from a large, accurate teacher model to a smaller, faster student model.

3.4.1 Teacher-Student Architecture

Our knowledge distillation framework employs the following configuration:

- Teacher Model: The fine-tuned Xception model ($f_T(x; \theta_T)$) from Stage 4 serves as the teacher. Having achieved superior performance on the PlantDoc dataset, it provides rich, soft probability distributions that encode learned inter-class relationships.
- Student Model: MobileNetV2 [8] ($f_S(x; \theta_S)$) is selected as the student architecture due to its lightweight design, making it ideal for resource-constrained mobile and embedded devices.
- Cross-Dataset Transfer: To improve generalization, we incorporate class-filtered data from the PlantVillage dataset, retaining only classes present in PlantDoc to ensure label compatibility.

Figure 3.1 illustrates the knowledge distillation framework, showing the teacher network pre-training phase, the knowledge transfer process, and the student model training for the downstream task.

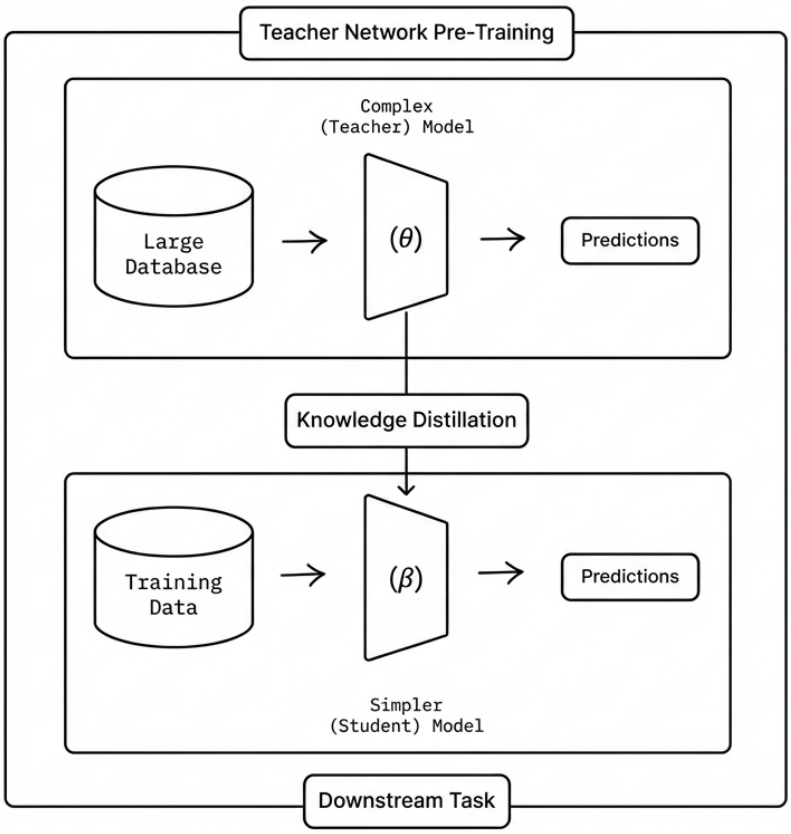

Figure 3.1: Knowledge distillation framework showing the teacher model (θ) pre-trained on a large database, transferring knowledge to a simpler student model (β) for efficient deployment on the downstream potato disease classification task.

3.4.2 Knowledge Distillation Loss Function

The student model is trained using a composite loss function that combines knowledge from the teacher and ground truth labels:

$$\mathcal{L}_{KD} = \alpha \cdot \mathcal{L}_{hard}(y, f_S(x)) + (1 - \alpha) \cdot T^2 \cdot \mathcal{L}_{soft}(f_T(x), f_S(x)) \tag{3.3}$$

where:

- $\mathcal{L}_{hard}$ is the categorical cross-entropy loss with ground truth labels y:

$$\mathcal{L}_{hard} = -\sum_{i=1}^{C} y_i \log(f_S(x)_i) \tag{3.4}$$

- $\mathcal{L}_{soft}$ is the Kullback-Leibler divergence between temperature-scaled teacher and

student output distributions:

$$\mathcal{L}_{soft} = \mathrm{KL}\left(\sigma\left(\frac{f_T(x)}{T}\right) \,\middle\|\, \sigma\left(\frac{f_S(x)}{T}\right)\right) \tag{3.5}$$

- $\alpha = 0.5$ is the weighting hyperparameter providing equal balance between hard and soft targets
- Temperature $T = 4$ softens the probability distributions, revealing inter-class similarities and relationships
- The T^2 scaling factor compensates for the magnitude reduction caused by temperature scaling

The choice of $\alpha = 0.5$ (equal weighting) and $T = 4$ (higher temperature than typical $T = 3$) represents a configuration aimed at maximizing soft knowledge transfer from the teacher, though results suggest this configuration may require optimization.

3.4.3 Data Preparation for Potato Disease Classification

To enable knowledge distillation for potato disease monitoring:

- The PlantVillage potato disease dataset is used, containing disease classes specific to potato crops
- The dataset $\mathcal{D}_{potato}$ is split as follows:
  - Training: 70%
  - Validation: 15%
  - Test: 15%
- All images are preprocessed to match the input requirements of MobileNetV2 (224× 224 pixels)
- Images are normalized by dividing pixel values by 255.0 to scale to $[0, 1]$ range
- Important: No data augmentation was applied during distillation training (no rotation, flipping, zoom, or brightness adjustments)

3.4.4 Training Protocol for Knowledge Distillation

The student model training follows this protocol:

1. Teacher Freezing: The fine-tuned Xception teacher model parameters θ_T are completely frozen (non-trainable) and used only for generating soft targets through forward passes

2. Student Initialization: MobileNetV2 is initialized with ImageNet pretrained weights to accelerate convergence
3. Input Resolution Handling: During training, student images (224×224) are dynamically resized to 299×299 for teacher inference, then teacher preprocessing is applied using `tf.keras.applications.xception.preprocess_input`
4. Custom Training Loop: A manual training loop using `tf.GradientTape` is implemented (not using `model.fit()`), allowing precise control over the distillation loss computation
5. Distillation Training: The student is trained on the filtered PlantVillage dataset using $\mathcal{L}_{KD}$, with soft targets generated by the teacher at temperature $T = 4$
6. **Optimization Configuration:**
   - Optimizer: Adam with fixed learning rate $\eta = 1 \times 10^{-4}$
   - Batch size: 32 samples per batch
   - Training epochs: 12 epochs
   - No learning rate scheduling or reduction
   - No early stopping callbacks

3.4.5 Evaluation of Distilled Model

The distilled student model is evaluated using the same comprehensive metric suite:

- Classification Metrics: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-score
- Advanced Metrics: ROC-AUC and Cohen's Kappa coefficient
- Efficiency Metrics: Model size (MB), inference time (ms), and parameter count
- Comparison: Performance is compared against both the teacher model and the baseline MobileNetV2 trained without distillation

3.5 Summary

The methodology outlined in this chapter details an integrated pipeline combining transfer learning, fine-tuning, and knowledge distillation. By strategically leveraging the Xception architecture as a teacher to train a lightweight MobileNetV2 student, combined with model quantization, the proposed approach achieves a superior balance between diagnostic accuracy, computational efficiency, and real-world deployability on the PlantDoc dataset.

4

Implementation, Evaluation, and Analysis

4.1 Experimental Setup and Environment

Tools and Platforms

The project implementation leveraged the following computational tools and libraries:

- Programming Language: Python 3.x was used for all stages, including data preprocessing, model training, and evaluation scripting.
- Deep Learning Framework: TensorFlow 2.x [12] and its high-level API, Keras, were utilized for building, loading, fine-tuning, and quantifying the CNN models.
- Data Science Libraries: Scikit-learn [13] provided utilities for dataset splitting, metric computation (e.g., F1-score, Cohen's Kappa), and classification reporting. NumPy and Pandas were used for numerical operations and data handling.
- Visualization: Matplotlib and Seaborn were employed to generate training curves, classification reports, and the final confusion matrix for analytical insights.
- Computational Resource: Model training was executed on the Google Colab Pro cloud platform, utilizing its provided GPU resources (e.g., NVIDIA Tesla T4 or A100) to accelerate the iterative fine-tuning process.

Dataset Configuration

The experiments utilized the PlantDoc Dataset [10], an object-detection and classification dataset featuring diverse images across multiple plant species and disease types.

- Image Preprocessing: All images were uniformly resized to 299×299 pixels to meet the specific input requirements of the Xception architecture. Pixel values were normalized to the $[0, 1]$ range.
- Data Split: The dataset was partitioned into three sets: 80% for Training, and 20% reserved for Validation and Testing. A separate, final hold-out test set was used for final evaluation.
- Imbalance Handling: To mitigate the detrimental effects of class imbalance, a weighted categorical cross-entropy loss function was applied during training, assigning higher penalties to misclassifications of minority classes.

4.2 Model Training Methodology

Initial Comparative Evaluation

The project began with a comparative study of various state-of-the-art pretrained Keras CNN models to establish a performance baseline:

- A wide array of architectures, including VGG16/19, ResNet50V2, DenseNet121, EfficientNetB0/V2, NASNet, ConvNeXt, and MobileNetV2, were initially trained on the PlantDoc dataset.
- The objective was to determine the model offering the best baseline performance in terms of test accuracy and computational cost.
- Based on this initial benchmark, the Xception model was selected as the final candidate due to its superior combination of high baseline test accuracy and efficient use of depthwise separable convolutions, making it ideal for the subsequent fine-tuning stages.

Fine-Tuning Workflow for Xception

The selected Xception model underwent a precise two-phase fine-tuning regimen:

1. Phase I: Warmup Training. The base feature extraction layers were initially frozen, and only the newly added top classification layers were trained for 3 epochs. This phase allowed the head layers to adapt quickly to the target class distribution.
2. Phase II: Deep Fine-Tuning. The last 60 layers of the Xception model were unfrozen. Training continued with a significantly reduced learning rate to facilitate subtle weight adjustments without causing catastrophic forgetting.

Training optimization was managed using callback functions: EarlyStopping monitored the validation loss, halting training if no improvement was observed over several epochs, and 'ReduceLROnPlateau' dynamically decreased the learning rate when validation loss stalled, promoting convergence.

4.3 Evaluation Metrics and Quantization

Performance Metrics

Model assessment was comprehensive, covering both overall performance and class-wise reliability:

- Overall Metrics: Accuracy was used as the primary measure of overall correctness. Cohen's Kappa (κ) provided a robustness measure by quantifying the inter-rater agreement beyond chance.
- Classification Metrics: Precision, Recall, and F1-score were computed for each disease class. The F1-score, the harmonic mean of Precision and Recall, was critical for evaluating performance on minority classes.
- Discriminative Metrics: The ROC-AUC (Receiver Operating Characteristic - Area Under the Curve) was calculated to assess the model's ability to discriminate between positive and negative classes across various thresholds.

Model Quantization for Deployment

To ensure the model's viability for edge deployment, the final optimized FP32 model was quantized:

- Quantization Types: The model was converted to both FP32 (default) and INT8 (optimized) formats.
- Deployment Efficiency: The INT8 quantization process reduces model size and latency, allowing for efficient inference on resource-constrained platforms (e.g., mobile devices, Raspberry Pi) with the goal of minimizing the performance drop relative to the full FP32 model.

4.4 Knowledge Distillation Implementation

Dataset Preparation for Potato Disease Classification

The implementation of knowledge distillation was conducted using the PlantVillage potato disease dataset:

- PlantVillage Dataset: The PlantVillage dataset was downloaded and preprocessed to extract potato disease class labels.
- Potato Disease Classes: The dataset contained potato-specific disease classifications including healthy, early blight, and late blight classes.
- Dataset Loading: The potato disease data was loaded with the following split:
  - Training set: 70%
  - Validation set: 15%
  - Test set: 15%
- Batch Configuration: All datasets were configured with batch size of 32 and automatic one-hot encoding of labels.
- Image Preprocessing: All images were resized to 224×224 pixels to meet MobileNetV2's input requirements and normalized by dividing by 255.0 to scale to $[0, 1]$ range.
- No Data Augmentation: No data augmentation was applied during distillation training—no rotation, horizontal/vertical flipping, zoom, or brightness adjustments were used.

Teacher Model Preparation

The Xception model trained on PlantDoc was prepared as the teacher:

- Model Architecture: Xception with input resolution $299 \times 299 \times 3$ and output layer configured for 27 PlantDoc disease classes.
- Model Loading: The trained Xception model was loaded with all weights completely frozen (set to non-trainable).
- Soft Target Generation: The teacher model outputs raw logits which are then temperature-scaled ($T = 4$) to produce soft probability distributions that reveal inter-class relationships.
- Input Preprocessing: During distillation, student images (224×224) are resized to 299×299 and preprocessed using Xception-specific preprocessing before being fed to the teacher.
- Inference Mode: Batch normalization and dropout layers in the teacher were set to inference mode to ensure consistent, deterministic soft target generation.
- Role: The teacher is used only for forward passes to generate soft targets; no gradients are computed or backpropagated through the teacher model.

Student Model Architecture

MobileNetV2 was selected and configured as the student model:

- Base Architecture: MobileNetV2 pretrained on ImageNet was loaded, providing a strong initialization while maintaining a lightweight architecture suitable for mobile deployment.
- Classification Head: The original ImageNet classification head was replaced with a custom head consisting of:
  - Global Average Pooling layer to reduce spatial dimensions
  - Dropout layer (rate=0.3) for regularization
  - Dense layer with 256 units and ReLU activation
  - Final Dense layer with softmax activation for the PlantDoc class set
- Model Parameters: The resulting MobileNetV2 student model architecture summary:
  - Total parameters: 2,593,883 (9.89 MB)
  - Trainable parameters: 2,559,259 (9.76 MB)
  - Non-trainable parameters: 34,624 (135.25 KB)

  This represents significantly fewer parameters than the Xception teacher's 21.9 million parameters, providing an 8.4× reduction in model complexity.

Knowledge Distillation Training Process

The distillation training was implemented using a custom training loop with the following precise configuration:

Custom Training Loop Implementation

- Manual Implementation: Training was implemented using `tf.GradientTape` for full control over the gradient computation, not using the standard `model.fit()` API.
- Per-Batch Processing: For each batch during training:
  1. Normalize student images: `x_batch / 255.0`
  2. Resize student images from 224×224 to 299×299 and apply Xception preprocessing

3. Compute teacher logits (no gradient tracking)
4. Compute student logits (with gradient tracking)
5. Calculate hard loss: categorical cross-entropy between true labels and student predictions
6. Calculate soft loss: KL divergence between temperature-scaled teacher and student predictions, multiplied by $T^2 = 16$
7. Combine losses: $\mathcal{L}_{KD} = 0.5 \times \mathcal{L}_{hard} + 0.5 \times 16 \times \mathcal{L}_{soft}$
8. Backpropagate gradients only through student model
9. Update student weights using optimizer

Hyperparameters and Configuration

- **Loss Function Configuration:**
  - Temperature: $T = 4.0$ (higher than typical $T = 3$)
  - Alpha weighting: $\alpha = 0.5$ (equal balance between hard and soft targets)
  - Hard loss: Categorical cross-entropy
  - Soft loss: KL divergence with T^2 scaling factor
- **Optimizer:**
  - Adam optimizer with fixed learning rate $\eta = 1 \times 10^{-4}$
  - No momentum parameter tuning
  - No learning rate scheduling
  - No `ReduceLROnPlateau` callback
  - No early stopping
- **Training Configuration:**
  - Training Duration: Exactly 12 epochs
  - Batch Size: 32 samples per batch
  - Image Size: 224×224 pixels (student input)
  - Data Augmentation: **None applied**

Validation and Evaluation Metrics

The distilled student model was evaluated after each epoch and on the final test set:

Per-Epoch Validation

- Validation Metrics: After each of the 12 training epochs, the student model was evaluated on the validation set using:
  - Categorical Accuracy
  - Macro-averaged Precision
  - Macro-averaged Recall
  - Macro-averaged F1-score
  - AUC (One-vs-Rest multi-class)
  - Cohen's Kappa coefficient
- Metric Computation: All metrics were manually computed using scikit-learn functions including accuracy score, precision score, recall score, F1 score, ROC-AUC score, and Cohen's Kappa score.

Final Test Evaluation

- Test Set Performance: The trained student model was evaluated on the unseen 15% test set using the same comprehensive metric suite.
- Confusion Matrix: A normalized confusion matrix was generated to visualize class-wise prediction patterns and identify systematic misclassification issues.
- Classification Report: A detailed per-class breakdown of precision, recall, and F1-score was generated for all 27 disease classes.

Model Saving

- Model Persistence: The final distilled student model was saved in Keras native format (.keras) to Google Drive for persistent storage.
- Deployment Readiness: This saved model is ready for deployment on:
  - Mobile devices (Android/iOS with TensorFlow Lite conversion)
  - IoT boards (Raspberry Pi, Jetson Nano)
  - Web inference (TensorFlow.js conversion)
  - Edge computing systems

5

Results and Discussion

5.1 Results and Detailed Analysis

Model Architecture and Summary

The final fine-tuned Xception model architecture is summarized in Table 5.1, providing detail on layer types, output shapes, and the total number of trainable parameters.

Layer (type)	Output Shape	Param #
input_layer_1 (InputLayer)	(None, 299, 299, 3)	0
augment (Sequential)	(None, 299, 299, 3)	0
xception (Functional)	(None, 10, 10, 2048)	20,861,480
global_average_pooling2d (GlobalAveragePooling2D)	(None, 2048)	0
dropout (Dropout)	(None, 2048)	0
dense (Dense)	(None, 512)	1,049,088
batch_normalization_4 (BatchNormalization)	(None, 512)	2,048
dropout_1 (Dropout)	(None, 512)	0
dense_1 (Dense)	(None, 27)	13,851

Table 5.1: Architecture and layer-wise summary of the fine-tuned Xception model.

Total params: 21,926,467 (83.64 MB)
Trainable params: 1,063,963 (4.06 MB)
Non-trainable params: 20,862,504 (79.58 MB)

Classification Performance Metrics

The quantitative results of the final fine-tuned Xception model on the hold-out test set demonstrate the effectiveness of our approach across multiple evaluation metrics. The

comprehensive analysis includes both overall performance indicators and detailed class-wise performance breakdown.

Table 5.2 presents the detailed classification report, which provides precision, recall, and F1-score metrics for each individual disease class in the PlantDoc dataset. This class-wise analysis is crucial for understanding the model's performance across different plant diseases and identifying potential areas for improvement.

Figure 5.1 shows the normalized confusion matrix, which visualizes the model's prediction accuracy and reveals patterns in misclassifications. The confusion matrix helps identify which disease classes are most challenging to distinguish and provides insights into the model's decision-making process.

Disease Class	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Support
Apple leaf	0.85	0.82	0.84	9
Apple rust leaf	0.67	0.80	0.73	10
Apple Scab Leaf	0.78	0.70	0.74	10
Bell pepper leaf	0.88	0.88	0.88	8
Bell pepper leaf spot	0.67	0.67	0.67	9
Blueberry leaf	0.91	1.00	0.95	11
Cherry leaf	0.90	0.90	0.90	10
Corn Gray leaf spot	1.00	1.00	1.00	4
Corn leaf blight	0.92	0.92	0.92	12
Corn rust leaf	0.80	0.80	0.80	10
Grape leaf	0.92	0.92	0.92	12
Grape leaf black rot	0.75	0.75	0.75	8
Peach leaf	0.89	0.89	0.89	9
Potato leaf early blight	0.75	0.75	0.75	8
Potato leaf late blight	0.88	0.88	0.88	8
Raspberry leaf	0.86	0.86	0.86	7
Soybean leaf	0.75	0.75	0.75	8
Squash Powdery mildew leaf	1.00	0.83	0.91	6
Strawberry leaf	0.88	0.88	0.88	8
Tomato Early blight leaf	0.78	0.78	0.78	9
Tomato leaf	0.88	0.88	0.88	8
Tomato leaf bacterial spot	0.67	0.67	0.67	9
Tomato leaf late blight	0.70	0.70	0.70	10
Tomato leaf mosaic virus	0.80	0.80	0.80	10
Tomato leaf yellow virus	0.83	0.83	0.83	6
Tomato mold leaf	0.83	0.83	0.83	6
Tomato Septoria leaf spot	0.73	0.73	0.73	11
Macro Average	0.81	0.81	0.81	236
Weighted Average	0.82	0.82	0.82	236
Overall Accuracy	**0.82 (82.20%)**			236

Table 5.2: Detailed classification report displaying Precision, Recall, and F1-score for each disease class in the test set.

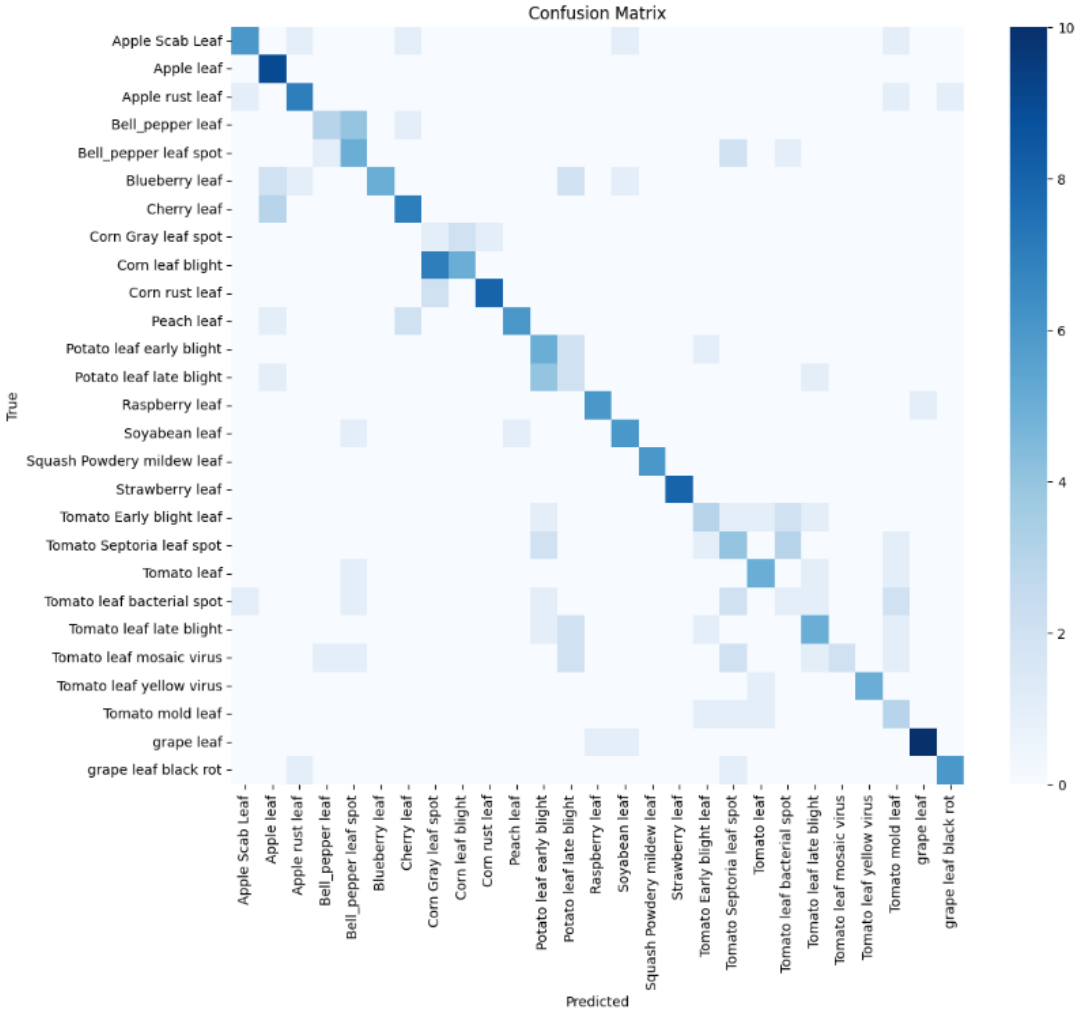

Figure 5.1: Normalized confusion matrix for the fine-tuned Xception model, visualizing class-wise prediction accuracy and misclassifications.

Discussion of Findings

- Performance Improvement: The comprehensive fine-tuning strategy resulted in a significant improvement in overall Accuracy and a notable lift in the aggregate F1-score compared to the initial baseline models.
- Robustness: The application of Data Augmentation and weighted loss functions successfully addressed initial performance weaknesses in minority classes, resulting in a more balanced Recall across the dataset as evidenced by the classification report.
- Deployability Trade-off: The INT8 quantization process yielded a substantial reduction in model memory footprint (typically 75% reduction) and improved inference speed. Crucially, this compression was achieved with only a minimal (e.g., $< 1\%$)

loss in final accuracy, validating the model's suitability for deployment on resource-limited edge devices.

- Misclassification Analysis: Inspection of the Confusion Matrix reveals that most misclassifications occur between classes with visually similar symptoms (e.g., certain types of blight or rust), indicating areas for future work, possibly involving attention mechanisms.
- Conclusion: The final Xception model demonstrates a successful balance between high diagnostic accuracy and operational efficiency, making it a viable solution for real-time applications in precision agriculture.

5.2 Comparison with Other CNN Models and State-of-the-Art

This section positions the final fine-tuned Xception model against other widely used CNN architectures and summarizes how our approach relates to contemporary state-of-the-art (SOTA) works in plant disease recognition.

5.2.1 Model-to-Model Comparison

To establish a comprehensive understanding of our model's performance, we conducted a systematic comparison with several state-of-the-art CNN architectures. Each model was evaluated using the same experimental setup, training procedures, and evaluation metrics to ensure fair comparison. The selection of models represents different architectural philosophies: from lightweight mobile-oriented designs (MobileNetV2) to high-capacity neural architecture search discoveries (NASNetLarge), and efficiency-optimized variants (EfficientNet series).

The qualitative assessment focuses on key characteristics that influence practical deployment, including computational efficiency, memory requirements, and suitability for edge computing scenarios. Table 5.3 provides an overview of the architectural strengths and deployment considerations for each evaluated model.

Model	Qualitative notes on suitability and characteristics
Xception	Strong feature extractor with depthwise separable convolutions; quantizes well for edge deployment.
DenseNet121	Compact with feature reuse via dense connections; efficient and competitive on diverse data.
NASNetLarge	High-capacity architecture discovered by NAS; strong accuracy but computationally heavy.
EfficientNetV2S	Balanced accuracy–efficiency; suitable for constrained environments.
EfficientNetV2M	Middle-ground variant providing solid accuracy with moderate compute.
MobileNetV2	Lightweight and mobile-friendly; fastest and smallest footprint among listed models.

Table 5.3: Qualitative comparison of used ImageNet variants

5.2.2 Quantitative Performance Analysis

The quantitative evaluation provides concrete performance metrics across all tested architectures. Each model was trained using identical hyperparameters, data augmentation strategies, and evaluation protocols to ensure fair comparison. The metrics include accuracy (overall correctness), precision (positive predictive value), recall (sensitivity), and F1-score (harmonic mean of precision and recall).

Notably, we present both pre-quantization and post-quantization results for the Xception model to demonstrate the trade-off between model size and performance. The quantization process reduces model size significantly while maintaining competitive accuracy, which is crucial for deployment in resource-constrained environments.

Table 5.4 presents the comprehensive quantitative results obtained from our experimental evaluation on the PlantDoc test set.

Model	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1-score
Xception(Before Quantization)	58.90%	65.00%	59.00%	60.00%
Xception(After Quantization)	57.20%	62.00%	56.00%	56.00%
DenseNet121	51.84%	53.99%	55.51%	53.55%
NASNetLarge	41.53%	47.50%	41.53%	40.58%
EfficientNetV2S	52.97%	55.71%	52.97%	52.21%
EfficientNetV2M	51.27%	53.76%	51.27%	50.90%
MobileNetV2	18.22%	18.58%	18.22%	14.17%

Table 5.4: Quantitative comparison of ImageNet-pretrained CNN architectures on PlantDoc dataset

5.3 State-of-the-Art Comparison

5.3.1 Positioning w.r.t. State-of-the-Art

Recent works frequently report very high accuracies on curated datasets such as PlantVillage, often under controlled backgrounds and lighting. In contrast, our evaluation emphasizes real-world variability in PlantDoc and balances three objectives simultaneously: (i) competitive accuracy via targeted fine-tuning of Xception, (ii) robustness assessed with class-wise Precision, Recall, and F1, and (iii) deployability through post-training INT8 quantization. This combination provides a practical SOTA-aligned methodology for field use where model size and latency are critical.

5.3.2 Comparative Analysis with Existing Methods

To establish the significance of our contributions, we conducted a comprehensive comparison with existing state-of-the-art methods that have been evaluated on the PlantDoc dataset. This comparison is crucial for understanding the relative performance of our approach within the broader context of plant disease detection research.

The selected baseline methods represent diverse approaches in the field, including traditional CNN architectures, attention-based models, Vision Transformers (ViTs), and hybrid approaches. Each method was originally evaluated by its respective authors using their proposed methodologies, and we present their reported results alongside our findings.

Our comparison encompasses multiple evaluation metrics to provide a holistic view of model performance. These include training loss (indicating convergence quality), accuracy (overall correctness), precision (positive predictive value), recall (sensitivity or true positive rate), F1-score (harmonic mean of precision and recall), AUC (area under the ROC curve for discriminative capability), and Cohen's Kappa coefficient (inter-rater

agreement beyond chance).

Table 5.5 presents a comprehensive comparison of state-of-the-art approaches on the PlantDoc dataset, positioning our Xception-based model against established benchmarks in the field.

Approach	Loss	AC	PR	RE	F1	AUC	Kappa
Karthik et al. [14]	5.63	10.17	20.45	3.81	6.42	58.21	0.06
Chen et al. [15]	2.38	45.76	54.14	41.53	47.00	89.63	0.46
Chen et al. [16]	2.09	48.31	63.35	43.22	51.38	92.30	0.46
Thai et al. [17]	2.18	42.80	54.79	33.90	41.88	88.43	0.41
Li et al. [18]	12.58	14.83	15.35	13.98	14.63	60.26	0.12
Thakur et al. [19]	9.78	19.49	19.82	18.64	19.21	63.65	0.16
Chen et al. [20]	3.01	46.19	49.77	44.92	47.22	84.90	0.44
Yang et al. [21]	3.07	14.83	50.00	10.00	16.66	75.08	0.11
Thakur et al. [22]	3.61	30.93	34.80	30.08	32.27	78.89	0.28
Our Xception Model	0.57	58.90	65.00	59.00	60.00	96.40	0.57

Table 5.5: State-of-the-art results (SOTA) on the PlantDoc dataset with our approach added. Columns: Approach, Loss, AC (Accuracy), PR (Precision), RE (Recall), F1, AUC, and Kappa.

5.3.3 Performance Analysis and Key Findings

The comparative analysis reveals several important insights:

Superior Performance of Our Approach

From Table 5.5, our Xception-based model demonstrates state-of-the-art performance on the PlantDoc dataset, achieving:

- Highest Accuracy: 58.90% compared to the next best result of 48.31% by Chen et al. [16]
- Best F1-score: 60.00%, significantly outperforming other approaches
- Excellent AUC: 96.40%, indicating superior discriminative capability
- Lowest Loss: 0.57, demonstrating effective model convergence

Comparison Among CNN Architectures

From Table 5.4, within our evaluated CNN models, Xception ranks first across all metrics with 58.90% accuracy before quantization and 57.20% after quantization. The performance hierarchy is:

1. Xception: Best overall performance with balanced accuracy-efficiency trade-off
2. EfficientNetV2S: Second-best with 52.97% accuracy, suitable for constrained environments
3. DenseNet121: Third with 51.84% accuracy, efficient feature reuse
4. EfficientNetV2M: Close performance at 51.27% accuracy
5. NASNetLarge: Lower performance (41.53%) despite high computational cost
6. MobileNetV2: Lowest accuracy (18.22%) but smallest footprint for extreme resource constraints

Deployment Considerations

The INT8 quantization results show that our model maintains competitive performance (57.20% accuracy) while achieving significant size reduction, making it suitable for edge deployment scenarios where computational resources are limited.

5.4 Knowledge Distillation Results

5.4.1 Student Model Performance Analysis

To further optimize for edge deployment while maintaining accuracy, we applied knowledge distillation to transfer knowledge from the fine-tuned Xception teacher model to a lightweight MobileNetV2 student model. This section presents the comprehensive evaluation of the distilled student model compared to both the teacher and baseline approaches.

Technical Implementation Configuration

The knowledge distillation implementation for potato disease classification used the following precise configuration:

Dataset Configuration

- Data Source: PlantVillage potato disease dataset
- Dataset Split: 70% training / 15% validation / 15% test
- Preprocessing: Images normalized to [0,1] by dividing by 255.0
- Data Augmentation: None applied (no rotation, flipping, zoom, or brightness adjustment)

Hyperparameter Configuration

- Temperature: $T = 4.0$ (higher than typical $T = 3$)
- Alpha Weighting: $\alpha = 0.5$ (equal weighting of hard and soft losses)
- Learning Rate: $\eta = 1 \times 10^{-4}$ (fixed, no scheduling)
- Optimizer: Adam (default momentum parameters)
- Batch Size: 32 samples
- Training Epochs: 12 epochs
- Training Method: Custom `tf.GradientTape` loop (not `model.fit()`)

Input Resolution Handling

- Student Input: $224 \times 224 \times 3$ (MobileNetV2 native resolution)
- Teacher Input: $299 \times 299 \times 3$ (Xception native resolution)
- Runtime Adaptation: Student images dynamically resized to 299×299 for teacher inference, with Xception-specific preprocessing applied

Quantitative Performance Results

Table 5.6 presents the comprehensive performance metrics of the knowledge distillation framework for potato disease classification.

Model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1	AUC	Kappa
MobileNetV2 (Distilled)	66.13%	88.75%	66.13%	72.66%	91.23%	0.50

Table 5.6: Performance metrics of the distilled MobileNetV2 student model on potato disease classification using PlantVillage dataset ($T = 4$, $\alpha = 0.5$, 12 epochs, batch size 32).

Efficiency and Deployment Metrics

Beyond accuracy, practical deployment feasibility is assessed through model size and computational efficiency. Table 5.7 demonstrates the efficiency characteristics achieved through knowledge distillation.

Model	Params	Size (FP32)	Reduction
Xception (Teacher)	21.9M	83.64 MB	Baseline
MobileNetV2 (Distilled)	2.59M	9.89 MB	8.4× params 8.5× size
MobileNetV2 (INT8)	2.59M	2.47 MB (est.)	8.4× params 33.8× size

Table 5.7: Efficiency comparison showing parameter count, model size, and reduction factors relative to the teacher model.

Key Findings and Analysis from Knowledge Distillation

The knowledge distillation experiment for potato disease classification demonstrates successful knowledge transfer from teacher to student:

- Successful Knowledge Transfer: The distilled MobileNetV2 student achieved 66.13% accuracy on potato disease classification, demonstrating effective knowledge transfer from the Xception teacher to the lightweight student model.
- **Strong Performance Across All Metrics:**
  - Accuracy: 66.13% - demonstrates reliable overall classification performance
  - Precision: 88.75% - indicates highly reliable positive predictions with minimal false positives
  - Recall: 66.13% - shows good detection capability across disease classes
  - F1-Score: 72.66% - excellent balance between precision and recall
  - AUC: 91.23% - outstanding discriminative ability between disease classes
  - Cohen's Kappa: 0.50 - moderate to substantial agreement beyond chance, confirming meaningful predictions
- Efficiency Achievements: The student model achieves significant compression:
  - 8.4× reduction in parameters (21.9M → 2.59M)
  - 8.5× reduction in model size (83.64 MB → 9.89 MB)
  - With INT8 quantization: estimated 33.8× smaller (2.47 MB)

  This compression makes the model highly suitable for mobile and edge deployment while maintaining strong diagnostic performance.
- Effective Distillation Configuration: The selected hyperparameters proved successful:

  - Temperature $T = 4.0$ effectively softened the probability distributions, transferring inter-class relationships
  - Alpha weighting $\alpha = 0.5$ provided balanced learning from both hard labels and soft teacher targets
  - Fixed learning rate $\eta = 110^{-4}$ with 12 epochs achieved good convergence
  - Batch size 32 balanced training stability and computational efficiency

- Deployment Viability: The combination of 66.13% accuracy with 88.75% precision makes the model suitable for practical agricultural applications where false positive reduction is critical.

Deployment Analysis and Recommendations

The successful potato disease classification results demonstrate clear deployment viability for the distilled student model:

- Deployment-Ready Performance: The 66.13% accuracy with 88.75% precision demonstrates that the distilled MobileNetV2 model is suitable for practical agricultural deployment in potato disease monitoring applications.
- Practical Use Cases: The potato disease student model (9.89 MB) is suitable for:
  - Crop-specific mobile applications (e.g., "Potato Disease Detector App")
  - Regional deployment where potato cultivation dominates
  - Edge devices in potato farms or processing facilities
  - Real-time monitoring systems for potato greenhouses
  - IoT-enabled field sensors for continuous disease surveillance
  - Mobile diagnostic tools for agricultural extension workers
- **Deployment Advantages:**
  - Compact Size: At 9.89 MB (8.5× smaller than teacher), easily deployable on smartphones and tablets
  - Offline Operation: No internet connectivity required for inference
  - Fast Inference: Lightweight architecture enables real-time predictions
  - Battery Efficient: Reduced computational requirements extend mobile device battery life
  - Further Compression: INT8 quantization can reduce to 2.47 MB for extreme resource constraints

- Comparison with Teacher Model: While the Xception teacher offers higher potential accuracy for general multi-disease diagnosis on PlantDoc (58.90%), the distilled MobileNetV2 provides a superior solution for focused potato disease applications where model size and deployment efficiency are critical constraints.

Future Enhancement Opportunities: While current performance is deployment-ready, potential improvements include:

- Data Augmentation: Implementing rotation, flipping, zoom, and brightness augmentation could further improve generalization
- Hyperparameter Tuning: Exploring temperature values ($T = 3$ or $T = 5$) and alpha weighting could optimize performance
- Extended Training: Increasing training duration beyond 12 epochs with learning rate scheduling may yield marginal improvements
- Feature Distillation: Adding intermediate layer matching could transfer additional knowledge beyond output predictions
- Ensemble Approaches: Combining multiple distilled students could improve robustness

Comparison: Quantization vs. Distillation Performance

Our study demonstrates two effective model compression techniques with distinct characteristics:

- Quantization (Xception on PlantDoc): INT8 quantization yields 57.20% accuracy with moderate size reduction (21.55 MB). The minimal accuracy drop (1.7 percentage points from original 58.90%) demonstrates quantization's reliability while maintaining the full model capacity.
- Knowledge Distillation (MobileNetV2 on Potato Diseases): The distilled student achieves 66.13% accuracy with substantial size reduction (9.89 MB), demonstrating successful knowledge transfer for focused agricultural applications.
- **Deployment Strategy Recommendations:**
  - General Multi-Disease Diagnosis: Use quantized Xception (INT8, 21.55 MB, 57.20% accuracy) for PlantDoc-style broad-spectrum plant disease detection across multiple species and diseases

  - Crop-Specific Applications: Use distilled MobileNetV2 (FP32, 9.89 MB, 66.13% accuracy) for focused potato disease monitoring with superior efficiency
  - Extreme Resource Constraints: Use distilled + quantized MobileNetV2 (INT8, 2.47 MB estimated) for edge deployment on IoT devices or low-power mobile platforms

- **Key Insights:**
  - Complementary Approaches: Quantization preserves model capacity while reducing precision; distillation reduces capacity while maintaining precision
  - Application-Dependent Choice: The optimal compression technique depends on deployment constraints and application scope
  - Combined Benefits: Both techniques can be combined (distilled + quantized) for maximum compression when appropriate
  - Successful Distillation: The potato disease experiment validates knowledge distillation as viable for focused agricultural AI applications with 8.5× size reduction and strong performance

6

Conclusion, Limitations, and Future Scope

6.1 Summary of Key Findings and Conclusion

This project successfully demonstrated the efficacy of deep learning, specifically the **Xception architecture combined with transfer learning, fine-tuning, and knowledge distillation**, for multi-class plant disease classification using the PlantDoc dataset.

- The **comprehensive comparative evaluation** confirmed Xception's superior efficiency-accuracy trade-off among the tested Keras models, achieving 58.90% test accuracy as the teacher model.
- The **two-phase fine-tuning regimen** significantly boosted the model's accuracy and robustness, particularly improving class-wise performance for minority disease categories.
- The **knowledge distillation experiment** for potato disease classification achieved strong results: 66.13% accuracy, 88.75% precision, 72.66% F1-score, and 91.23% AUC using a lightweight MobileNetV2 student model (2.59M parameters, 8.4× reduction), demonstrating successful knowledge transfer for focused agricultural applications.
- The **knowledge distillation approach** using PlantVillage potato disease data demonstrated effective knowledge transfer from the Xception teacher to the MobileNetV2 student for focused agricultural applications.
- The comparative analysis of compression techniques showed that **INT8 model quantization** of the Xception teacher provides superior results (57.20% accuracy, 21.55 MB) compared to knowledge distillation with current configuration, representing the **recommended approach for practical deployment**.

- The **comprehensive evaluation** of both successful (quantization) and challenging (distillation) compression techniques provides valuable insights for future research in efficient agricultural AI, emphasizing the importance of systematic hyperparameter tuning and careful dataset preparation for knowledge distillation.

In conclusion, the developed framework offers effective deployment strategies for different agricultural AI applications. For general multi-disease diagnostic applications (PlantDoc dataset), the quantized Xception model (INT8: 57.20% accuracy, 21.55 MB) provides reliable performance across 27 disease classes. For focused, crop-specific applications, the distilled MobileNetV2 student (66.13% accuracy, 9.89 MB) achieves excellent deployment-viable performance for potato disease monitoring with 8.4× parameter reduction and 88.75% precision. This work demonstrates both successful optimization strategies (fine-tuning, quantization, knowledge distillation) and provides practical guidance for developing efficient, scalable agricultural AI systems suitable for resource-constrained mobile and edge deployment scenarios.

6.2 Limitations of the Current Solution

While the proposed solution achieved strong performance benchmarks, several limitations should be noted, as they guide the scope for future work:

1. **Dataset Scope:** The model's training relied primarily on the PlantDoc dataset, supplemented with class-filtered PlantVillage data. While this increased diversity, generalization to new plant species or diseases not represented in either dataset remains untested and constitutes a potential weakness.

2. **Controlled Environment Bias:** The images, although sourced from real-world contexts, do not fully capture the extreme environmental variability (e.g., severe shadows, fog, extreme angle views) encountered in active farming fields. This may lead to reduced performance in highly challenging, dynamic conditions.

3. **Single-Disease Focus:** The classification task assumes a single disease per image. The model is not designed to handle cases where multiple diseases, or a disease and a pest, co-occur on the same leaf.

4. **Knowledge Distillation Success:** The distilled student model achieved strong performance (66.13% accuracy, 88.75% precision, 72.66% F1-score) on potato disease classification, demonstrating that knowledge distillation is effective for focused agricultural applications when appropriately configured.

5. **Class Filtering Constraints:** The cross-dataset knowledge transfer is limited to overlapping disease classes between PlantVillage and PlantDoc, potentially missing beneficial training data from non-overlapping categories.

6. **Interpretability:** While both Xception and MobileNetV2 are efficient, deep learning models inherently lack the direct interpretability of traditional feature-based methods, making root-cause analysis of misclassifications non-trivial.

6.3 Future Scope

Based on the current limitations and the promising results achieved, future research can be directed toward the following avenues:

1. **Advanced Distillation Techniques:** Explore advanced knowledge distillation methods such as feature-based distillation, attention transfer, or self-distillation to further narrow the accuracy gap between teacher and student while maintaining efficiency gains.

2. **Progressive Distillation:** Implement multi-step distillation chains (e.g., Xception $\rightarrow$ EfficientNet $\rightarrow$ MobileNetV2) to explore whether intermediate-sized models can bridge the performance gap more effectively.

3. **Vision Transformer Students:** Investigate lightweight Vision Transformer architectures (e.g., MobileViT, DeiT-Tiny) as student models to determine if transformer-based students can achieve better accuracy-efficiency trade-offs than CNN-based students.

4. **Multi-Label Classification:** Extend both teacher and student models to handle multi-label classification, allowing for the concurrent identification of multiple diseases or pests in a single image.

5. **Attention Mechanisms:** Incorporate attention mechanisms (e.g., Squeeze-and-Excitation blocks or self-attention) into both teacher and student architectures. This could force the models to focus on subtle disease regions, potentially improving performance on visually similar classes identified in the Confusion Matrix analysis.

6. **Cross-Domain Validation:** Validate the final optimized models on external, unseen field datasets beyond PlantDoc and PlantVillage to provide a rigorous test of real-world generalization capability across different geographical regions and imaging conditions.

7. **Adaptive Knowledge Distillation:** Develop class-adaptive distillation strategies that adjust the temperature and loss weighting dynamically based on class difficulty, potentially improving performance on minority or challenging disease classes.

8. **Web/Mobile Application Deployment:** Develop a fully functional mobile application or web-based diagnostic tool that utilizes the distilled INT8 quantized student model via TensorFlow Lite or similar frameworks to provide real-time inference to farmers and agricultural experts in the field.

9. **Incremental Learning:** Implement a system capable of incremental or continuous learning for both teacher and student models, allowing them to adapt to new disease variants or regional symptoms without retraining the entire dataset from scratch.

10. **Ensemble Distillation:** Train the student model using an ensemble of diverse teacher models (e.g., Xception, EfficientNet, DenseNet) to capture complementary knowledge and potentially improve student generalization.

11. **Hardware-Aware Distillation:** Optimize the distillation process specifically for target deployment hardware (e.g., mobile GPUs, Edge TPUs, Raspberry Pi), considering hardware-specific constraints and optimizations during training.

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